WEEK 11 · LECTURE L2 · UNIT IV

HR as Digital Change Agent

Capability, mandate and credibility, the politics of transformation, and reskilling the HR function itself.

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AFTER THIS LECTURE YOU SHOULD BE ABLE TO

What this lecture prepares you for

- Explain what a change agent needs: capability, mandate and credibility.
- Explain why HR professionals face reskilling more than replacement.
- Map stakeholders and apply stakeholder salience, force field analysis, Kotter's errors and Pfeffer on power.

COURSE OUTCOMES

CLO 5 (HR as digital change agent).

HR'S OWN EXPOSURE

A reskilling case, not a redundancy case

Moderate automation risk

HR officer roles typically carry moderate automation risk: routine transactions automate, judgment does not.

The real risk

Experienced HR staff are at greater risk of being left without the skills the new model needs than of being replaced.

The response

Build capability internally: data literacy, technology judgment and change skill.

A COURSE FRAMING

Three things a change agent needs

Capability
Data literacy, technology judgment, change skill. HR must reskill itself first.

Mandate
Formal authority from the CHRO and the Board to change processes across functions.

Credibility
Earned by early, visible wins that matter to line managers, not only to HR.

Scully-Russ and Torraco (2020) argue HR should look beyond its role as the employer's functional agent: giving workers voice and shaping how technology is designed.

Map the stakeholders before you need them

Stakeholder	What they care about	What they can block
CFO	Cost, return, risk	Budget
Line managers	Staffing, output, time	Daily adoption
IT	Security, integration, workload	Technical delivery
Frontline staff	Ease, language, fairness	Use, through workarounds
Gig workers	Earnings, voice	Retention of the network

THEORY IN DEPTH · MITCHELL, AGLE AND WOOD (1997)

Which stakeholders get attention

THE CORE IDEA

Stakeholder salience depends on three attributes: power, legitimacy and urgency.

HOW IT WORKS

Those with all three are definitive stakeholders; those with only legitimacy are often ignored.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Salience is perceived by managers, so it can be misjudged.

IN PRACTICE

Gig workers have legitimacy and urgency but little power; a fair strategy gives them weight anyway.

EXAM LENS

Classify each stakeholder by the three attributes; this structures a strong analysis.

THEORY IN DEPTH · LEWIN (1951)

Force field analysis

THE CORE IDEA

Any situation is held in balance by driving forces and restraining forces.

HOW IT WORKS

Change happens more easily by reducing restraining forces than by pushing harder.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

A simplification: forces interact and change over time.

IN PRACTICE

Removing a restraint (no regional-language interface) may achieve more than another push (a mandate to use the app).

EXAM LENS

Pair with Kotter: Kotter adds driving forces; Lewin reminds you to remove restraining ones.

THEORY IN DEPTH · KOTTER (1995)

Eight errors that make transformations fail

THE CORE IDEA

From studying change efforts, Kotter listed common errors, starting with not establishing enough urgency.

HOW IT WORKS

Others include no powerful guiding coalition, under-communicating the vision, declaring victory too soon, and not anchoring change in the culture.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Evidence is drawn from Kotter's consulting experience rather than systematic study.

IN PRACTICE

Declaring victory at go-live is the most common error in HR technology programs.

EXAM LENS

Note the evidence limitation; it shows critical engagement with a famous model.

THEORY IN DEPTH · PFEFFER (1992)

Getting things done needs power

THE CORE IDEA

In organizations, change requires understanding and using power, not only good ideas.

HOW IT WORKS

Map interests and influence, build alliances, and time moves for when support is strongest.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Power can be used for narrow ends; the theory is descriptive, not a license.

IN PRACTICE

A sound analytics case fails without allies among line managers and in finance.

EXAM LENS

Use Pfeffer to argue that HR's technical expertise is insufficient without political capability.

PRACTICE FOR THE END-TERM EXAMINATION

Questions to rehearse

"HR cannot lead digital transformation until it transforms itself." Discuss using the capability, mandate and credibility framing and Scully-Russ and Torraco (2020). **20 marks**

A strong answer: explains each element; reskilling over replacement; HR beyond functional agent; evaluates feasibility.

Using stakeholder salience, force field analysis and Pfeffer, analyze the politics of an HR technology transformation. **20 marks**

A strong answer: classifies stakeholders; identifies driving and restraining forces; proposes coalition-building; notes ethical limits of power.

List Kotter's errors in transformation and evaluate the evidence behind them. **10 marks**

A strong answer: names the errors and the consulting-based evidence limitation.

CARRY THESE INTO THE EXAMINATION

Three things to remember

1. **HR must reskill itself before it can lead others**
2. **Map stakeholders by power, legitimacy and urgency**
3. **Reduce restraining forces rather than pushing harder**

SET READINGS · FROM THE LESSON PLAN

Read for this lecture

- Scully-Russ, E., & Torraco, R. J. (2020), pp. 84–85 and 88–89 (HR beyond its role as the employer's functional agent).

COMPANION

Each set reading is explained in the matching Unit Reader on rksingh.tech/materials.

THEORY SOURCES · FOR REFERENCE

Sources for this lecture

Works named on the slides of this lecture. They are background sources, not set readings.

Kotter, J. P. (1995). Leading change: Why transformation efforts fail. *Harvard Business Review, 73*(2), 59–67.

Lewin, K. (1951). *Field theory in social science: Selected theoretical papers* (D. Cartwright, Ed.). Harper & Row.

Mitchell, R. K., Agle, B. R., & Wood, D. J. (1997). Toward a theory of stakeholder identification and salience: Defining the principle of who and what really counts. *The Academy of Management Review, 22*(4), 853–886. https://doi.org/10.2307/259247

Pfeffer, J. (1992). *Managing with power: Politics and influence in organizations*. Harvard Business School Press.

Scully-Russ, E., & Torraco, R. J. (2020). The changing nature and organization of work: An integrative review of the literature. *Human Resource Development Review, 19*(1), 66–93. https://doi.org/10.1177/1534484319886394